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Survival Strategy

We cannot afford to lose our players. The onus lies on the Government to make hockey attractive to corporates.

Indian hockey has been bleeding for years with no permanent cure, other than a few dressings as first-aid. As a player, witnessing Indian hockey's latest crisis has been quite painful. Our national sport, which gave us eight Olympic golds, has always been deprived of many things which should actually have been automatic. Earlier, when the team won international events and gold medals regularly, it was difficult to meet public expectations. This was due to the increased competition from other nations which got ahead due to advanced training and sports science.

In that time, our frustrations started to increase with challenges and results. The earlier hockey federations lacked adequate funds and professionalism, and sponsors were hardly interested in the game. The Sports Ministry's efforts were appreciated but even then urgent action was needed on incentives like a basic daily allowance in training camps, top quality diet for the players and state-of-the-art technology. With every passing day, financial constraints became evident.

When the latest crisis broke, the player in me wanted the issues raised by the players to be settled on a long-term basis. What has normally happened in the past is that knee-jerk measures like rewards for winning a big tournament are adopted to appease the team. The future needs of the game and the next generation are ignored.

We must not allow this to happen now. There should be a system in place that can address the needs of all future hockey players along with the feasible demands of today's players. The game needs serious money which Hockey India (HI) sadly does not have.

This is where the Government and the corporate sector have to step in. The onus lies on the Government to shell out funds and leave it to HI to make the game attractive to corporates. It can begin by providing money to HI for organising domestic leagues and nationals for the men and women's team. New tournaments can also

be organised to encourage corporate funding and making the game popular. HI is actually in the final stages of planning a new professional hockey league. This will be a vital move. Apart from declaring rewards for players, I believe, the corporate sector must adopt individual tournaments to provide funds to the federation for long-term use.

These events should be conducted on a professional basis with incentives for both participation and achievement. Even though HI is bound by a contract till 2011, these are areas that can attract a greater variety of investment. It is also true that several organisations are waiting for a permanent body to govern Indian hockey before stepping in with their funds.

There is another way of turning around the cash-strapped sport. Like starting a Hockey Support Fund, where funds and support from corporates, NRIs and individuals can be pooled. HI must ensure that it allocates money from this pool judiciously to all areas of development—like players' dues, development of hockey academies, remuneration and pensions for elderly superstars who gave everything to the sport. Film stars can help a great deal by organising or playing benefit games.

We need to do what the Cricket Board did years ago—recognise the fact that India is a budding market. This is something that the International Hockey Federation (FIH) has already realised and exploited, by allowing India to host the World Cup after 27 years. The FIH knows that

India needs to participate in every event for the game to become popular in the world and is therefore taking a special interest in developing Indian hockey. Already, the FIH has assured the HI that the amount left after the World Cup will be pumped into India's hockey development.

I am glad the crisis has been sorted out. It takes ages to build a good team and we are not very far from key tournaments. The players need to focus on their training for the upcoming tournaments and we need to show them that justice will be delivered. ■



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